



Protecting Youth Sports in the Sports-Betting Era

A Michigan framework for prevention, incident reporting, and privacy-protective measurement

Donavan Norman | Founder & Executive Director | Northstar Civic Institute

Updated September 28, 2026 | [Read online](#)

STRATEGIC POSITION

Lead with prevention and measurement, not a broad campaign against legal sports betting and not causal claims the evidence cannot sustain. NCI proposes a voluntary, one-school-year Michigan pilot that measures exposure, betting-related pressure, spectator conduct, reporting capacity, and officiating climate without monitoring individual students.

Executive summary

Michigan has enough evidence to build basic safeguards around youth sports, but not enough K-12 data to claim that sports betting is already causing local misconduct. College athletics now documents betting-related harassment. National youth research shows meaningful exposure and some gambling participation. Michigan already has a school-based prevention channel through the Michigan Gaming Control Board. What the state does not have is a common, privacy-protective way to determine whether those risks are converging in school sports.

The practical next step is a bounded pilot: one willing district, regional conference, or cohort of schools; a published measurement plan; shared incident definitions; prevention through trusted school channels; independent evaluation; and aggregate reporting only. The pilot should produce usable tools even if it finds little betting-specific misconduct.

46%

of Division I men's basketball respondents reported negative or threatening messages from someone who bet on their game. [1]

36%

of surveyed U.S. boys ages 11–17 reported gambling in the prior year; 12% reported sports-related gambling. [5]

9,330

MHSAA officials were registered for 2025–26, up 4.9% from the prior year. Registration is not the same as retention. [9]

\$150K

distributed by MGCB to more than 30 booster clubs, with another \$100,000 pool opening Oct. 1, 2026. [7]

THE DECISION

Michigan should test whether gambling exposure, betting-related pressure, adult fan conduct, and officiating climate are interacting in K-12 sports—and build the reporting and prevention tools needed before a severe incident forces action.



Start with the evidence boundary

The strongest version of this brief separates three different things: evidence that a risk exists somewhere, evidence that Michigan schools have a practical prevention opportunity, and evidence that a particular problem is occurring in Michigan youth sports. The first two are established. The third is not.

Michigan's PBA/NIL rules create a second prevention touchpoint

MHSAA now permits Michigan high-school student-athletes to earn compensation through individual personal-branding activity, subject to its rules. Current MHSAA guidance also bars PBA associated with gaming or gambling, restricts school-connected entities from arranging deals, and requires athletes to disclose finalized PBA opportunities to MHSAA. [12]

Those rules do not answer the research questions in this brief. They do show why gambling prevention and athlete-mobility education should be coordinated rather than treated as separate conversations. A student can face betting-related messaging as a fan, athlete, online user, and emerging commercial participant at the same time.

Evidence area	Current finding	Responsible interpretation
College athlete harassment	In the NCAA's 2025 GOALS study, 51% of Division I men's basketball respondents reported performance-based social media abuse and 46% reported negative or threatening messages from someone who bet on their game. [1]	Strong evidence of a college-sport problem in a high-exposure group. It is not a K-12 prevalence estimate.
Betting-related fan blame	In the NCAA's February 2026 SNAP survey, one in three men's basketball players reported direct blame for betting losses; 26% of those athletes reported verbal or physical abuse. [2]	Useful for defining betting-related pressure and abuse. The sample covers Division I college athletes, not high school athletes.
Online abuse	NCAA/Signify analysts reviewed 1.3 million posts and comments, verified more than 5,000 abusive or threatening posts, and classified 12% of verified abuse as betting-related. [3]	Shows a betting component within verified abuse. It does not show that 12% of all athlete messages are betting-related.
Youth gambling and exposure	A nationally representative Common Sense Media survey of 1,017 boys ages 11–17 found that 36% reported gambling in the prior year and 12% reported sports-related gambling. Large shares reported gambling ads on YouTube, social media, and live or streaming sports. [5]	Direct evidence of exposure and participation among boys. It should not be generalized to all Michigan youth or treated as a causal study.
Early participation	A 2026 NCPG/Harris Poll found that 65% of adults age 21 and older recalled gambling before 21; 23% recalled placing a sports bet before 21. [6]	A national retrospective signal. Recall-based adult responses are not a current teen prevalence measure.
Michigan prevention capacity	MGCB reported more than 30 participating booster clubs, \$150,000 distributed, and another \$100,000 funding pool opening Oct. 1, 2026. [7]	A ready implementation channel for prevention messages and pilot recruitment—not proof of outcomes.
Officials and game climate	MHSAA registered 9,330 officials for 2025–26, 4.9% more than the prior year. [9] Nationally, adult fan behavior has been a longstanding concern for athletic administrators. [10]	The current Michigan trend is recovery, not a continuing statewide decline. The pilot should measure local return rates, sport-specific gaps, and reasons for leaving.

PUBLIC-FACING CAUTION

The brief should never imply that every sideline argument, official departure, or athlete concern is caused by sports betting. The point of the pilot is to determine whether a betting-specific component exists, how often it appears, and whether prevention tools are reaching the people who need them.



The gap Michigan can actually solve

School-sport systems already document pieces of the problem—ejections, removals, threats, social-media concerns, complaints, official availability, and student well-being—but they do not use a shared definition of betting-related pressure or a common denominator for comparison. Prevention campaigns also report reach more often than behavior or reporting outcomes. That leaves decision-makers unable to distinguish isolated incidents from an emerging pattern.

Measure each link instead of assuming the chain

Stage	What the pilot should observe
1. Exposure	Students and adults encounter betting ads, gambling-like mechanics, fantasy contests, odds, and wagering talk.
2. Normalization or pressure	Betting language becomes part of peer, family, spectator, or online conversation around individual performance.
3. Conduct or safety event	Comments escalate into blame, direct messages, abuse, threats, integrity solicitation, or disruptive game-day behavior.
4. Institutional response	Schools, officials, coaches, platforms, law enforcement, or regulators receive and address the report.
5. Outcome	The response affects safety, well-being, reporting confidence, prevention reach, participation, or official retention.

NCI proposal: a one-school-year Michigan pilot

NCI proposes a voluntary pilot involving one district, one regional athletic conference, or a cohort of roughly six to ten schools. It should cover at least fall, winter, and spring competition; use existing incident and communication systems wherever possible; and publish the protocol before data collection begins.

Phase	Deliverable
Design: 60 days	Choose participants; agree on definitions, roles, legal review, privacy rules, baseline measures, survey instruments, and referral procedures.
Baseline: opening weeks	Document contest volume, existing codes, reporting pathways, prevention exposure, recent incident categories, and official recruitment/return patterns.
Implementation: school year	Deliver prevention messages, use the common reporting template, administer short voluntary pulse surveys, and review data quality at fixed intervals.
Learning: closeout	Publish aggregate findings, a spectator-code template, a reporting guide, a scorecard prototype, and a recommendation to scale, revise, or stop.

A PILOT, NOT A STATEWIDE VERDICT

A small cohort can test definitions, burden, privacy, and usefulness. It cannot establish statewide prevalence or support rankings of schools, sports, communities, or demographic groups.



Pilot governance: assign the work before collecting data

Actor	Primary role
Participating district, conference, or school cohort	Own implementation, designate a data steward, use existing safety and due-process policies, and decide who may access identifiable incident records.
Michigan Gaming Control Board	Provide approved prevention content, connect eligible booster funding, and advise on responsible-gaming and referral resources. MGCB should not receive student-level pilot data.
MHSAA	Advise on sport operations, official-facing tools, definitions, and statewide dissemination. Participation should not convert the pilot into a compliance ranking system.
Independent evaluator or university partner	Finalize the protocol, protect analytic independence, audit classification consistency, suppress small cells, and prepare the public learning report.
Student, parent, coach, official, and booster advisory group	Review language, burden, reporting pathways, and unintended effects before and during implementation.
NCI / Michigan Sports Opportunity	Convene the framework, maintain the scorecard prototype, document implementation lessons, and translate findings into public tools and future research questions.

Michigan Sports Opportunity scorecard module: Fan Behavior and Gambling Exposure

The original concept is stronger when it is treated as two related subdomains—exposure and prevention, then conduct and response—rather than one undifferentiated score. The module can still sit within the broader Michigan Sports Opportunity scorecard.

Dimension	Public question	Example indicators
Gambling exposure environment	Where are students and families encountering betting or gambling-like content?	Sports media, social feeds, fantasy contests, paid brackets, games and reward mechanics, peer/family settings, school-adjacent communications.
Prevention reach and recall	Are trusted adults and students receiving and remembering prevention messages?	Exposure to messages; recall; knowledge of age limits, warning signs, and help resources; channel used.
Game-day behavior climate	Are adults maintaining safe, respectful competition environments?	Verbal abuse, ejections, threats, confrontations, spectator removal, repeat incidents, code enforcement.
Athlete pressure and harassment	Are athletes receiving betting-related comments, blame, direct contact, or requests for information?	In-person comments, direct messages, posts, individual-stat pressure, lineup/injury questions, or integrity solicitation.
Official and coach climate	Can officials and coaches serve safely and sustainably?	Return intention, assignment coverage, reasons for declining or leaving, safety perceptions, respect climate.
Reporting and response	Can a concern be reported, classified, referred, and resolved consistently?	Channel clarity, response time, documentation, follow-up, referral, outcome, repeat conduct.
Equity and burden	Are risks or pilot burdens concentrated in particular settings?	Aggregate analysis by sport, level, gender, geography, school resources, and other lawful factors; time burden on staff and participants.



Minimum viable measurement set

- Contest volume by sport and level so incidents can be reported per 100 contests rather than as raw counts alone.
- Fan-conduct incidents categorized by general misconduct, betting-related language, direct athlete contact, threat or safety concern, integrity solicitation, and unknown/unclear relation to betting.
- Short, voluntary, anonymous baseline and follow-up surveys for age-appropriate students, parents, coaches, and officials. The student instrument should avoid collecting gambling account details or identifiable disclosures.
- Prevention reach and recall—not only whether a message was posted or a training was completed.
- Reporting-pathway measures: awareness, time to first review, action taken, referral, closure, and repeat incidents.
- Official recruitment, assignment coverage, return intention, and stated reasons for reducing or ending service where available.
- Staff burden, implementation cost, and data quality so the pilot can be judged on feasibility as well as need.

Use a clear incident taxonomy

Category	Working definition	Pilot treatment
Routine / non-reportable	Ordinary cheering, criticism, or disagreement that does not violate existing conduct rules.	Do not count as misconduct or infer a betting connection.
Disruptive conduct	Repeated taunting, prohibited language, refusal to follow staff direction, or behavior leading to warning or removal.	Record under existing policy; add a betting-related flag only when language or evidence supports it.
Targeted abuse or pressure	Blame tied to a wager, direct messages, performance-stat pressure, or requests for nonpublic team information.	Protect the recipient; preserve relevant evidence; route through the designated reporting process.
Threat, safety, or integrity concern	Threat of violence, stalking, doxxing, extortion, coercion, or an attempt to manipulate competition.	Use existing emergency, mandatory-reporting, law-enforcement, platform, and athletic-governance procedures. Pilot reporting is secondary to safety.

Privacy, ethics, and safety guardrails

- No monitoring of student phones, private accounts, browsing history, geolocation, or personal devices.
- No public identification of students, families, officials, coaches, complainants, teams, or participating schools. Suppress small cells and rare-event combinations.
- Separate pilot analysis from discipline and eligibility decisions. Existing school policy, notice, due process, and legal obligations continue to govern individual cases.
- Collect only what is necessary; assign a named data steward; use role-based access; establish a short retention schedule; and document deletion after the final report.
- Complete legal and ethics review before launch, including parent notice or consent requirements for student surveys and protocols for minors.
- Create immediate escalation pathways for threats, self-harm, suspected exploitation, integrity manipulation, or disclosures that trigger mandatory reporting.
- Provide stigma-free referral information. Michigan's problem-gambling support line is available at 1-800-GAMBLER, with free and confidential help.

NON-NEGOTIABLE BOUNDARY

The pilot is a prevention and learning system. It should not become covert student surveillance, a public school ranking, or a shortcut around existing safety, discipline, or due-process rules.



Decide in advance what the pilot can change

A pilot is only useful if decision-makers know what evidence would justify continuation. The closeout report should make one of three findings.

Decision	Evidence threshold	Next step
Scale	Shared definitions are workable; participation and reporting are adequate; prevention reaches the intended audiences; data reveal actionable patterns; privacy and burden remain acceptable.	Expand to a larger cohort or statewide toolkit, while preserving voluntary participation and independent evaluation.
Revise	The concept is useful but reporting is inconsistent, response rates are low, indicators are ambiguous, or staff burden is too high.	Narrow the measures, simplify the template, improve training, extend the period, or change the cohort before expansion.
Stop	The pilot requires intrusive monitoring, cannot protect confidentiality, produces no usable distinction between ordinary conduct and betting-specific risk, or becomes primarily punitive or reputational.	End the data collection, publish the lesson, retain only useful prevention materials, and delete pilot data on schedule.

Policy posture: what to do and what to avoid

Do	Avoid
Lead with a narrow, testable question.	Do not frame the project as a campaign against legal sports betting.
Distinguish college evidence, national youth exposure, Michigan implementation capacity, and local K-12 findings.	Do not present one population or setting as direct proof about another.
Use MGCB prevention resources and trusted school channels.	Do not confuse message distribution with measured impact.
Include athletes, officials, coaches, parents, boosters, and student voice.	Do not design a top-down enforcement system without the people expected to use it.
Report rates, definitions, limitations, and uncertainty.	Do not publish raw counts, school rankings, or small-cell data that invite misinterpretation or identification.
Use existing safety and due-process pathways for individual cases.	Do not let a research pilot become hidden discipline, eligibility enforcement, or social-media surveillance.

Immediate next steps

1. Prepare a two-page pilot prospectus naming the lead institution, participating cohort, one-school-year timeline, expected staff burden, data steward, evaluator, and deliverables.
2. Request a 30-minute design conversation with MGCB, MHSAA, one district or regional athletic conference, one booster partner, and a public-health or university evaluator. The ask is protocol input and pilot feasibility—not endorsement of conclusions.
3. Draft the common incident definitions, privacy rules, spectator-code addendum, and short survey instruments before seeking data.
4. Align the communication plan with MGCB's existing booster channels and the new funding pool opening October 1, while keeping pilot evaluation independent from campaign promotion.
5. Publish the protocol, then issue a short midyear implementation note and a final public learning brief with a dashboard prototype and scale/revise/stop recommendation.



Conclusion

Michigan does not need to wait for school sports to reproduce the same betting-related harassment documented in college athletics. It also should not claim that the pattern already exists without local evidence. A carefully bounded pilot can close that gap while producing immediate value: clearer conduct definitions, safer reporting pathways, stronger prevention delivery, better protection for athletes and officials, and a record of what should—or should not—be scaled.

The test is simple. Can Michigan learn early without turning prevention into blame or measurement into surveillance? The design in this brief is built to answer that question.

Selected sources and notes

Sources verified September 19, 2026. Statistics are reported with their populations and limitations. The NCI pilot, scorecard module, incident taxonomy, governance assignments, and decision rules are proposed design elements—not findings from an existing Michigan K-12 study.

- [1] NCAA, “DI men’s basketball student-athletes experiencing increased social media harassment, NCAA survey reveals,” Feb. 5, 2026. [Source](#)
- [2] NCAA, “Division I student-athletes express concerns about sports betting’s impact on college basketball,” Mar. 25, 2026. [Source](#)
- [3] NCAA, “NCAA calls on fans, social media platforms to curb abuse as it releases first online harassment study,” Oct. 10, 2024. [Source](#)
- [4] NCAA, “NCAA urges gambling commissions to eliminate prop bets,” Jan. 15, 2026. [Source](#)
- [5] Common Sense Media, Betting on Boys: Understanding Gambling Among Adolescent Boys, Jan. 29, 2026. [Source](#)
- [6] National Council on Problem Gambling, “National Survey Finds Widespread Gambling Participation Before Age 21,” Mar. 2, 2026. [Source](#)
- [7] Michigan Gaming Control Board, “MGCB Marks Responsible Gaming Education Month with \$150,000 Boost for School Booster Clubs,” Sept. 2, 2026. [Source](#)
- [8] Michigan Gaming Control Board, “Michigan Gaming Control Board launches ‘Don’t Bet on Your Future’ statewide campaign,” May 11, 2026. [Source](#)
- [9] Michigan High School Athletic Association, “2026-27 MHSAA Officials Registration Underway,” June 15, 2026. [Source](#)
- [10] National Federation of State High School Associations, “Parents & Adult Fans Biggest Challenge Today,” Sept. 5, 2019. [Source](#)
- [11] Associated Press, “5 major sports leagues and players associations ask for protections from sports bettors’ threats,” Sept. 15, 2026. [Source](#)
- [12] Michigan High School Athletic Association, Name, Image, Likeness / Personal Branding Activity overview. Current guidance accessed September 19, 2026; includes restrictions on school-connected arrangements and PBA associated with gaming or gambling. [Source](#)

Publication and support note

This brief is independent policy analysis for research and educational purposes. It does not constitute legal, medical, clinical, or school-discipline advice. Individual safety concerns should follow applicable school policy, mandatory-reporting requirements, and emergency procedures.

For free and confidential gambling-related support in Michigan, call 1-800-GAMBLER or use the resources available through the Michigan Gaming Control Board.

[NCIRESEARCH.ORG](https://nciresearch.org) | [Read this brief online](#)